

COMMUNICATION SKILLS

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Nutrition Education & Patient Counseling

Objectives

- At the end of the lecture, the students will be able to understand:
- Communication skills
- Effective Counselor-Client Relationships
- Personal Characteristics of Counselors
- Facilitative Levels
- Nonverbal Communication
- Verbal Communication

Objectives (cont,)

- Counselor-Client Focus Identification
- Listening Responses
- Action Responses
- Sharing Responses
- Teaching Responses
- Choosing the Appropriate Response

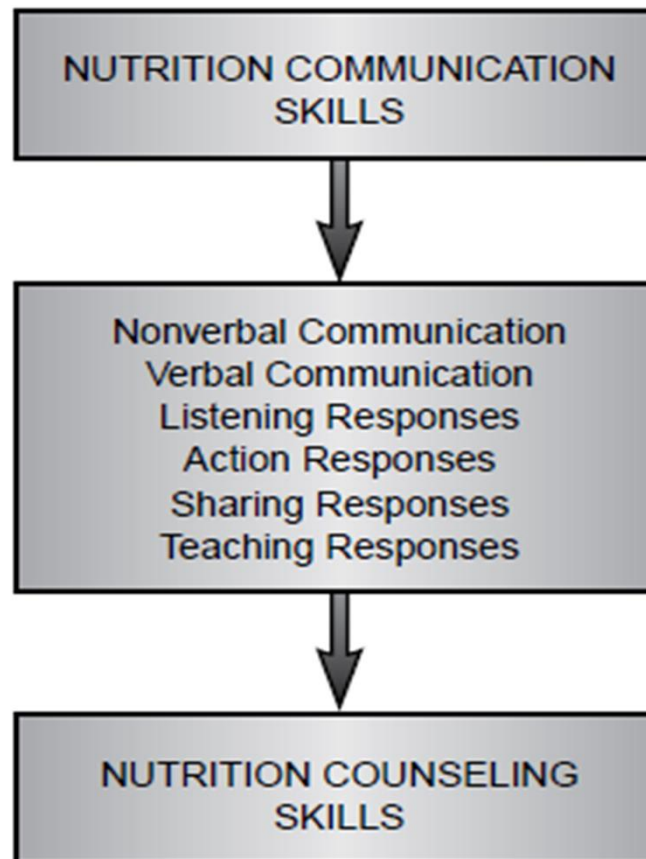
Communication Skills

- Communication is defined as the process of understanding and sharing meaning.
- Communication skills involve:
 - **Listening to others (Receiving) message**
 - **Asserting/ Expressing (Sending)**
- Barriers to communication can lead to misunderstanding and confusion



Effective Counselor-Client Relationships

- Communication skills form the **foundation** for nutrition counseling.
- Every step in the nutrition care process requires an ability to communicate.



Personal Characteristics of Counselors

- Counseling can facilitate another person's growth.
- The way counselors respond to others can greatly influence how clients think and act in the future.
- Many clients come to a counseling session feeling that no one has really ever listened to them.
- By finding someone who is focused on them and shows great interest in their past eating problems, they become more willing to discuss those parts of their lives that may be most connected to success and failure in the goal of eating in a healthy manner.

Facilitative Levels

- The five levels illustrate a gradual progression in the counselors' ability to respond appropriately to clients' problems.
- **Level 1: The response shows no understanding and no direction in relation to the client's position.** When the client brings up a crucial personal topic, the counselor starts talking about his or her own personal problems.
- **Level 2: The response shows no understanding but some direction.** The counselor presents only general advice: when the client expresses difficulty with a weight-loss strategy, the response is, "Well, don't worry about it."

Facilitative Levels (cont,)

- **Level 3: The response shows understanding but no direction.** The counselor might say, “You feel afraid because you’re not sure how to avoid food offers from friends.”
- **Level 4: The response shows understanding and some direction.** The counselor reacts to the client’s deficits and provides details related to the problems, saying, “You feel afraid because you can’t say ‘no’ and you want to avoid eating high-calorie foods.”
- **Level 5: The response shows understanding and specific direction.** It contains the deficit, the goal, and one explicit step for overcoming the problem and reaching the objective

Nonverbal Communication

- Clients' nonverbal behavior can affect the direction of the interview.
- Effective counselors can identify nonverbal cues as signals for unspoken feelings.
- **There are three forms of client nonverbal behavior:**
 1. **Kinesics**
 2. **Paralinguistic**
 3. **Proxemics**
- Nonverbal communication **has meanings** associated with behaviors for each region of the body and a general category of autonomic responses.
- The effect or meaning of each nonverbal behavior varies from person to person and culture to culture.

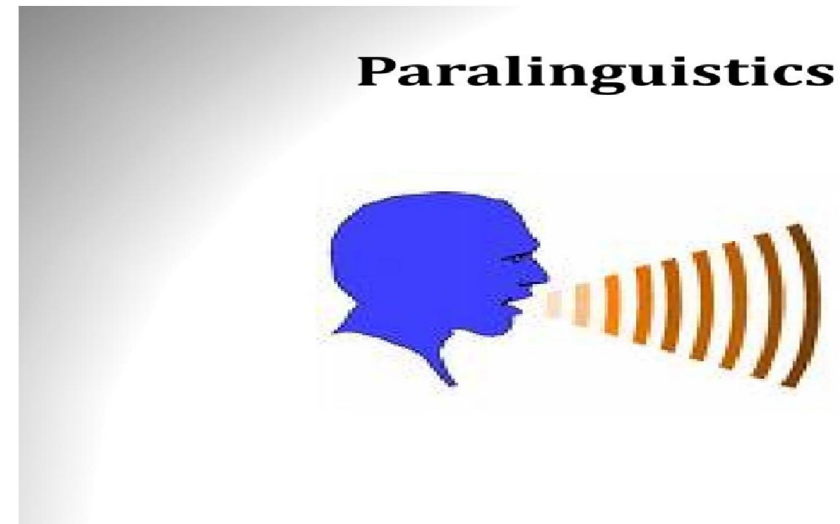
Nonverbal Communication (cont,)

1. **Kinesics:** includes a variety of physical behaviors (e.g., facial expressions, body language).

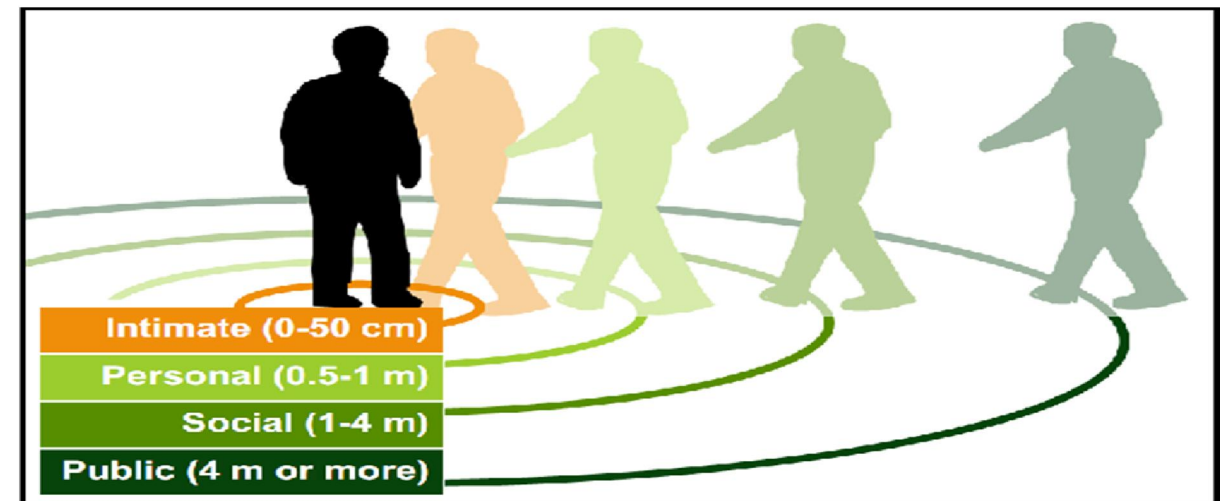


Nonverbal Communication (cont,)

2. Paralinguistics: refers to how the client's message is delivered (e.g., tone of voice).

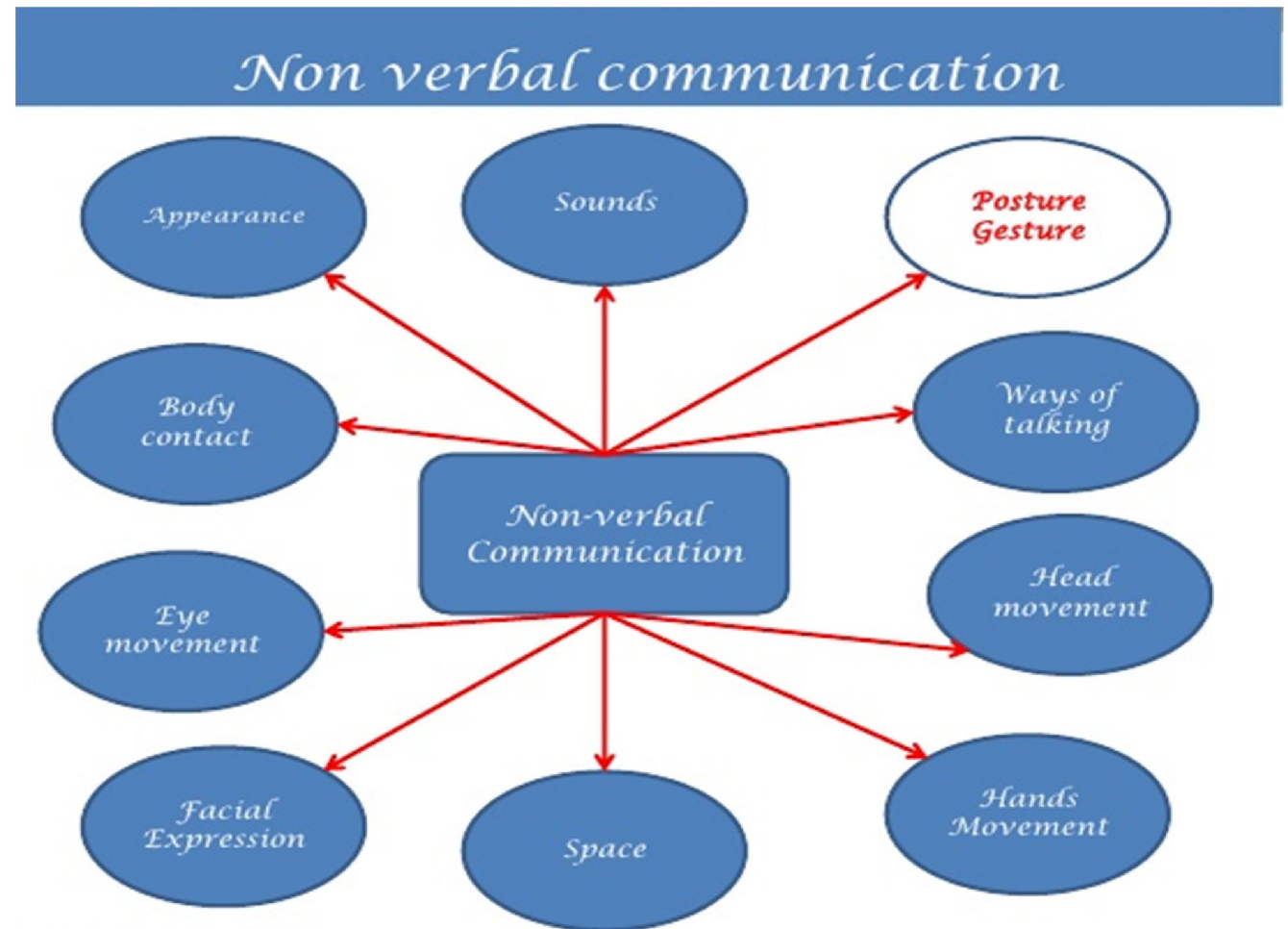


3. Proxemics: involves environmental and personal space.



Counselor Nonverbal Communication

- Can have a **great impact** on the relationship.
- Nonverbal counselor behaviors that seem to be most important include expressions: in the eyes and face, head nodding and smiles, body orientation and posture, some vocal cues, and physical distance between practitioners and clients.



Verbal Communication

- The counselor's knowledge and command of verbal skills can play an important part in directing the interview.

➤ Conversational Style

- Beginning counselors tend to fall into a kind of conversational mode that is very comfortable for them. Such a style is typical of a friendly chat with a neighbor.

➤ Cultural Values

- Dietary behavioral change is directly tied to culture.
- Culture is very important in each individual's ability to be successful in making healthful behavioral changes.

Counselor-Client Focus Identification

- Once nutrition counselors have altered their conversational style appropriately, there are several specific ways they can learn to provide direction and focus for an interview.
 1. Focus on the client (e.g. feeling)
 2. Focus on the main theme or problem
 3. Focus on family & others (people in the client's life who affect dietary change).
 4. Focus on mutual issues or a group (This focus involves the nutrition counselor and client relationship or the entire family).
 5. Focus on the nutrition counselor (This focus includes self disclosure or an "I" statement).
 6. Focus on cultural/environmental/contextual issues (e.g. family values, or economic trends)

Listening Responses

1. Clarifying

- Clarification is posing a question, often after an ambiguous client message.
- Clarification may be used to make the previous message explicit and to confirm the accuracy of the counselor's perceptions of it.

2. Paraphrasing

- Restating or rephrasing the client's message in the counselor's own words.

3. Reflecting (Reflective Listening)

- Reflection of feelings is used to rephrase the affective part of the message.
- This form of listening response has three purposes:
 1. To encourage expression of more feelings
 2. To help clients experience feelings more intensely
 3. To help clients become more aware of feelings that dominate them.

Listening Responses (cont,)

- **4. Summarizing**

- Guidelines for summarization:

1. Attend to major topics and emotions apparent as the client speaks.
2. Summarize key ideas into broad statements.
3. Do not add new ideas.
4. Decide whether it is wise for you as a counselor to summarize or ask the client to summarize the broad themes, agreements, or plans.

Action Responses

- **1. Probing**
- Gathering information on clients' eating patterns.
- Probing can involve both open and closed questions.
- **Probing has a variety of purposes:**
 1. to begin an interview
 2. to encourage client elaboration or to obtain information
 3. to elicit specific examples of clients' nutrition-related behaviors, feelings, or thoughts
 4. to develop client commitment to communicate

Action Responses (cont,)

- **2. Attributing or Affirming**
- Attributing responses point to the client's current potential for being successful in a designated activity.
- **This response has several purposes:**
 - to encourage the client who lacks initiative or self-confidence to do something
 - to expand the client's awareness of personal strength
 - to point out a potentially helpful client action

Action Responses (cont,)

- **3. Confronting**

- Confrontation is a complex of skills resulting in a client's examination of core issues.
- It may be contained in a *paraphrase, a reflection of feeling, or any other skills*.
- Counselors should keep several basic rules in mind before using them:
 1. Make the confronting response a description instead of a judgment or evaluation of the client's message or behavior.
 2. Cite specific examples of the behavior.
 3. Prior to confronting the client, build rapport and trust
 4. Offer the confrontation when the client is most likely to accept it.
 5. Do not overload the client with confrontations

Action Responses (cont,)

- **4. Interpreting**

- An interpreting response is an active reply that gives a possible explanation of or association among various client behaviors.
- It has three intended purposes:
 1. to identify the relationship between the client's behavior and nonverbal messages
 2. to examine the client's behavior using a variety of views or different explanations
 3. to help the client gain self-understanding as a basis for behavior change or action

Action Responses (cont,)

- **Guidelines for counselors in interpreting responses:**

1. Look for the client's basic message.
2. Paraphrase the message to the client.
3. Add your own understanding of what the message means (motive, defense, needs, style, etc.).
4. Keep the language simple and the level close to the client's message.
5. Indicate that you are offering tentative ideas.
6. Elicit the client's reactions to your interpretations.

Sharing Responses

- The sharing responses involve counselor self-expression and content that refers to the practitioner, the client, or the emotions of either one.
- Counselors can use two sharing responses:
- **1. Self-Disclosure**
- Counselors verbally share information about themselves.
- It has four purposes:
 - 1. to provide an open, facilitative counseling atmosphere
 - 2. to increase the client's perceived
 - 3. to provide a model to assist in increasing the client's disclosure level
 - 4. to influence the client's perceived or actual behavioral changes.

Sharing Responses (cont,)

- **2. Immediacy**

- Involves the counselor's reflections on a present aspect of a thought or feeling about self, clients, or a significant relationship issue.
- Immediacy has two purposes:
 1. It can bring expressed feelings or unresolved relationship issues into the open for discussion.
 2. It can provide immediate feedback about the counselor's and client's feelings and aspects of the relationship as they occur in the session.

Teaching Responses

- Usually this response is used when clients are in the “action” stage of change.
- **There are three verbal responses associated with teaching responses:**

1. Instructions

- Counselors tell clients what changes in current intake are necessary to achieve new eating behaviors.

2. Verbal Setting Operation

- Motivate clients to understand the purpose of and to use counseling and/or treatment.

Teaching Responses (cont,)

- **3. Information Giving/ Delivering**
- **There are some guidelines indicate how to deliver information:**
 1. Limit the amount of information given at one time.
 2. Ask for and discuss client's feelings and biases about information.
 3. Know when to stop giving information
 4. Wait for the client's cue of readiness for additional information after providing a group of facts.
 5. Be specific, clear, detailed, concrete, concise, and simple
 6. Repeat important information.
 7. Present all relevant facts
 8. Use oral and written material together

Choosing the Appropriate Response

- To determining appropriate responses include:
 1. Identification of the purposes of the interview.
 2. Assessment of the potential effects of the selected replies and strategies on client answers and outcomes.



References

- Business Communications for Success; adopted by Saylor Foundation under a Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-ShareAlike 3.0 License.
- Snetselaar, L. G. (2009). *Nutrition counseling skills for the nutrition care process*. Sudbury, Mass: Jones and Bartlett.

*Thank You
For Your Attention*

